

WORLD MYTHOLOGY

THE ILLUSTRATED GUIDE



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GILGAMESH

The great epic of mortality



A terracotta mask of the demon Humbaba (Sumerian Huwawa) from the city of Ur. Masks like this were used to ward off the many demons who were thought to people the Mesopotamian world.

The fullest version of the great Gilgamesh epic is an Akkadian text from Assurbanipal's library at Nineveh. Gilgamesh, described as "two-thirds god and one third man", has been oppressing his subjects in Erech. When they appeal to the gods for a counterpart to keep their ruler in check, the gods create Enkidu, the archetypal savage, who is covered with hair and lives with the wild beasts. He loses his special nature when he has intercourse with a prostitute, who introduces him to civilization. He then engages Gilgamesh in combat, after which the two become close friends and embark on heroic exploits, such as the killing of Humbaba. On their return to Erech, the goddess Ishtar invites Gilgamesh to be her consort, but he scornfully rejects her advances. Enraged, she sends the "Bull of Heaven" against him, but Gilgamesh and Enkidu slay the creature.

The gods decide that Enkidu must die for his part in the slaying of Humbaba and the Bull. Enkidu's fate brings home to Gilgamesh the reality of death, and so he sets out to discover the secret of eternal life. Crossing the Waters of Death, he visits the one man who has gained immortality, Utnapishtim, who tells him of an immortalizing plant at the bottom of the sea. Accompanied by Utnapishtim's boatman, Gilgamesh recovers the plant, but it is stolen by a snake before he can use it (this is how the skin-sloughing snake acquires the gift of rejuvenation). Gilgamesh finally returns to Erech, and takes the boatman on a tour of his splendid city.

The Sumerian versions

There are five extant Sumerian texts about Gilgamesh, an early Sumerian king who was later deified; these were woven together and reinterpreted by Babylonian scribes to form a connected epic.

The third of the texts relates how the goddess Inanna send the huge Bull of Heaven to Gilgamesh after he has rejected her seduction attempts (see above).

In the fourth text, Inanna wishes to cut down a tree to make a bed and chair, but is unable to do so because the tree is guarded by various demonic creatures. However, at Inanna's request, Gilgamesh expels these monsters, and from the wood of the tree the goddess fashions two objects, called *pukku* and

mukku – perhaps a ritual drum and drum-stick. For some reason these fall down to the underworld, from which Enkidu undertakes to retrieve them. Once there, he is unable to return. However, the god Enki makes a

hole in the ground, through which the shade of Enkidu emerges, to tell Gilgamesh of the gloomy state of those deported there.

The final composition of the sequence is usually entitled the Death of Gilgamesh, but the text may in fact refer to Enkidu's death: in any case, its theme is the inevitability of death and the vanity of all hopes of immortality. This, indeed, is the message of the Gilgamesh epic as a whole as expressed in its most complete (that is, Babylonian) version.



The slaying of the demon Humbaba, recounted in both Sumerian and Akkadian texts. Gilgamesh stands on the left, wearing a crown.

THE FLOOD

Destruction and survival

The flood myth is a dramatic reflection of the unpredictable inundations of the Tigris and Euphrates rivers. The fullest story occurs in the epic of Atrahasis. Mankind is created to serve the gods and to relieve them of the necessity of labour. But within twelve hundred years, humanity multiplies so rapidly that their noise disturbs the gods' peace. Enlil seeks to reduce their numbers by sending first a plague and then a twice-repeated drought, but each time his plans are thwarted by the wise Enki, who reveals Enlil's intentions to Atrahasis, pious king of Shurupak, and instructs him in counteractive measures. Finally, Enlil compels the other deities to send a great flood, binding them with an oath of secrecy. Enki circumvents this by speaking not directly to Atrahasis but to the reed hut in which the king is living. Following Enki's counsel, Atrahasis builds a boat in which he takes refuge with his family and various animals when the flood is launched. The gods find that, without human beings, their sustenance is cut off and the need for them to labour returns: they lament what has happened. After seven days, the flood subsides and Atrahasis emerges to offer a sacrifice to the gods. Enlil is initially furious, but finally accepts the continuance of mankind. However, he proposes measures to limit population growth, instituting classes of priestesses debarred from having children and introducing infant mortality. Atrahasis is rewarded with eternal life and a position among the gods.

THE FLOOD IN THE GILGAMESH EPIC

Utnapishtim, the survivor of the flood in the Gilgamesh epic (see p.60), recounts in detail the building of a boat in the form of a perfect cube, and gives a vivid picture of the effects of the flood. He tells how, as the waters finally subsided, he sent out a dove, a swallow and a raven to reconnoitre the ground and how he then emerged to offer a sacrifice, around which all the gods clustered to "smell the sweet savour". These features link the Babylonian story closely to the Biblical flood narrative. Finally, Ea tells the angry Enlil that he should not seek entirely to wipe out the human race but should punish them, when necessary, by sending wild animals, famine or plague. Enlil accepts the advice and rewards Utnapishtim with the gift of immortality.

The Sumerian flood myth

The flood myth survives in three main versions, whose basic features show derivation from a common prototype. Humanity seriously offends the gods, and is punished at the instigation of the deity Enlil by a flood intended to wipe out the race. However, one man and his family are spared by the intervention of the god Enki or Ea to make a fresh start for humankind. The Sumerian deluge myth survives only in a fragmentary state but it is clearly the origin of all the later Mesopotamian versions. It describes the institution of Sumerian civilization, kingship, city-states and irrigation.

After a lacuna in the text, Enki is found speaking of the gods' decision to destroy mankind by a flood, in spite of the regrets of the mother goddess, Inanna. Enki resolves to save the pious

King Ziusudra and tells him of the gods' purpose by speaking through the reed-wall of the king's house. At this point the text is again broken, but presumably Ziusudra receives instructions to build a boat, for there follows a description of a seven-day flood, when "the storm-winds tossed the huge boat on the great waters". Then Utu, the sun god, appears in his barque, bringing back light, and Ziusudra emerges to offer a sacrifice to

An and Enlil, who would appear to have been responsible for the flood. They are appeased and repopulate the earth and renew its vegetation and finally grant Ziusudra "eternal life, like a god".

The third version of the myth is that in the eleventh tablet of the Gilgamesh epic (see margin, above), in which the hero Utnapishtim tells how he and his family survived the flood.



Utu, with other deities, in his barque. In this vessel, in which he was thought to traverse the sky daily, the sun god appeared to Ziusudra in the flood myth.